

Footprints Without Feet

Class 10 CBSE • Footprints Without Feet • H.G. Wells

Detailed Exam-Oriented Solutions

Complete NCERT exercise solutions, character sketches, vocabulary, important quotations, extracts, very-short/short/long answers, value-based and competency-based questions, plus MCQs.

1. Chapter Information

Title	Footprints Without Feet
Author	H.G. Wells
Genre	Science fiction / mystery story
Main Characters	Griffin, Mrs Hall, Mr Jaffers, the clergyman and his wife

2. Character Sketches

Griffin

A brilliant scientist who discovers how to make the human body invisible by making it transparent. However, he is also lawless, selfish and quick-tempered. He uses his discovery for theft, revenge and escape rather than responsible purposes. His scientific brilliance is therefore contrasted with poor moral judgement.

Mrs Hall

The landlord's wife at the inn in Iping. She tries to be friendly to Griffin but finds his appearance, secrecy and temper strange. The mysterious movements of the furniture convince her that the room is haunted.

Mr Jaffers

The village constable who attempts to arrest Griffin. He remains committed to his duty even when Griffin becomes invisible and eventually manages to resist him until he is knocked unconscious.

The Clergyman and his Wife

They discover that money has been stolen from their study even though they cannot see the thief. Their experience adds to the mystery surrounding Griffin.

3. Important Words & Meanings

transparent	allowing light to pass through; clear
lawless	not obeying the law
wanderer	a person who moves from place to place without a fixed home
eccentric	strange or unconventional
solitude	the state of being alone
irritable	easily annoyed or angered
clergyman	a religious minister
hysterics	uncontrolled emotional excitement

constable	a police officer
magistrate	a judicial officer
invisible	unable to be seen
witchcraft	magical practices believed to cause supernatural effects

4. Important Quotations / Lines

“Brilliant scientist though he was, Griffin was rather a lawless person.”

Significance: The line captures the central contrast between Griffin’s scientific ability and his unethical behaviour.

“The explanation of the mystery was really simple enough.”

Significance: The invisible footprints are explained scientifically rather than supernaturally.

“My reason for coming to Iping is a desire for solitude.”

Significance: Griffin wants privacy because he is hiding his identity and unusual condition.

“The room was haunted by spirits.”

Significance: Mrs Hall interprets the invisible scientist’s actions through a supernatural explanation.

“Griffin had shaken himself free, and no one knew where to lay hands on him.”

Significance: The ending demonstrates the practical power of invisibility and Griffin’s ability to escape arrest.

5. Complete NCERT Textbook Solutions

A. Read and Find Out — Page 26

Q. How did the invisible man first become visible?

Answer: Griffin became visible when he stepped in mud and left footprints. Later, he dressed himself in clothes, shoes, an overcoat and a hat, which made his invisible body visually identifiable to others.

Q. Why was he wandering the streets?

Answer: Griffin had become invisible but had no clothes or money. After setting fire to his landlord’s house in revenge, he had to flee and became a homeless wanderer.

B. Read and Find Out — Page 29

Q. Why does Mrs Hall find the scientist eccentric?

Answer: Griffin arrives in winter wearing bandages, dark glasses and unusual clothing, refuses conversation, demands solitude and behaves irritably. His secrecy and strange appearance make him seem eccentric.

Q. What curious episode occurs in the study?

Answer: A clergyman and his wife hear noises and the sound of money being taken from the desk. When they enter, the room appears empty, but the money has disappeared. The invisible Griffin has stolen it.

Q. What other extraordinary things happen at the inn?

Answer: Mrs Hall hears a strange sniff, the hat on the bedpost flies at her and the bedroom chair suddenly moves and pushes the couple out. The invisible Griffin is responsible, but Mrs Hall believes the room is haunted.

C. Think About It

Q. ‘Griffin was rather a lawless person.’ Comment.

Answer: Griffin repeatedly breaks the law. He sets fire to his landlord's house, steals clothes and money, robs the clergyman's home, attacks people and resists arrest. His invisibility increases his ability to escape, but it does not make his actions right.

Q. How would you assess Griffin as a scientist?

Answer: Griffin is highly intelligent and scientifically brilliant because he discovers a method to make the human body transparent. However, his scientific achievement is not matched by moral responsibility. He uses his discovery selfishly and criminally. Thus he is a brilliant but unethical scientist.

D. Talk About It — Model Answers

Q. Would you like to become invisible? What advantages and disadvantages would you foresee?

Answer: Invisibility might offer privacy and allow a person to observe situations without being noticed. However, it could also create serious ethical and practical problems, including misuse, fear, loss of accountability and temptation to commit wrongdoing. Therefore its risks would be substantial.

Q. Are there invisible forces or aspects of matter?

Answer: Yes. Magnetism, gravity, radio waves and many forms of radiation cannot be seen directly with the naked eye, although their effects can be observed or measured. Microscopic structures such as atoms and molecules are also not directly visible to ordinary vision.

Q. What makes glass or water transparent? Is human invisibility scientifically possible?

Answer: Transparency depends on how light interacts with a material and whether visible light can pass through it with limited scattering or absorption. Making a human body completely invisible is far more complicated because the body contains many tissues that interact with light differently. Griffin's invention is therefore a science-fiction concept rather than an established method.

6. Extract-Based Questions

“The explanation of the mystery was really simple enough.”

1. What mystery is being explained?

Answer: The appearance of footprints without a visible person.

2. Who is responsible for the footprints?

Answer: Griffin.

3. How did his body become invisible?

Answer: He used rare drugs to make his body transparent.

4. Why do the footprints appear?

Answer: His bare feet become visible when they pick up mud.

“Brilliant scientist though he was, Griffin was rather a lawless person.”

1. What contrast is presented?

Answer: Scientific brilliance versus moral irresponsibility.

2. Name one crime Griffin commits.

Answer: He sets fire to his landlord's house / steals money and clothes.

3. Why does he remove his clothes?

Answer: To escape unseen after becoming invisible.

4. What does the line suggest about scientific knowledge?

Answer: Knowledge without ethical responsibility can be dangerous.

“The horrified people in the bar found themselves staring at a headless man!”

1. Why does Griffin appear headless?

Answer: His head is invisible.

2. What has he removed?

Answer: His bandages, whiskers, spectacles and false nose.

3. Who arrives shortly afterwards?

Answer: Constable Jaffers.

4. What happens finally?

Answer: Griffin becomes completely invisible and escapes after struggling with the constable.

7. Very Short Answer Questions

Q. Who is Griffin?

Answer: A scientist who discovers how to become invisible.

Q. Where does Griffin go after London?

Answer: Iping.

Q. Who owns the inn?

Answer: Mrs Hall and her husband.

Q. Why does Griffin wear bandages?

Answer: To hide his invisible head and create the appearance of a face.

Q. What does Griffin steal from the clergyman?

Answer: The housekeeping money.

Q. What does Mrs Hall think has entered the furniture?

Answer: Spirits.

Q. Who is Jaffers?

Answer: The village constable.

Q. Why is Griffin called lawless?

Answer: He repeatedly breaks the law.

Q. What happens to Jaffers?

Answer: He is knocked unconscious.

Q. Does Griffin get arrested?

Answer: No; he escapes by becoming invisible.

8. Short Answer Questions

Q. Why did Griffin enter the London store?

Answer: He was suffering from the cold because he was invisible and naked. He entered the store to obtain warmth, food and clothes.

Q. Why did Griffin go to Drury Lane?

Answer: He wanted clothes and materials that could hide the empty space around his invisible head. He obtained bandages, glasses, a false nose, whiskers and a hat.

Q. Why does Mrs Hall consider Griffin an eccentric scientist?

Answer: His strange appearance, secrecy, demand for solitude, irritability and unusual behaviour make her think he is an eccentric scientist rather than an ordinary guest.

Q. Why does the clergyman think the study is mysterious?

Answer: He hears money being taken from the desk but finds nobody in the room. The invisible Griffin has stolen the money, making the event appear supernatural.

Q. How does Griffin escape the constable?

Answer: He removes his remaining clothes one by one, becoming increasingly invisible. Eventually Jaffers cannot see or hold him, and Griffin escapes.

9. Long Answer Questions

Q. Describe Griffin's character.

Answer: Griffin is a brilliant scientist who discovers a remarkable method of making the human body transparent. Yet he is morally irresponsible and lawless. He takes revenge on his landlord by setting fire to the house, steals clothes and money, robs the clergyman and attacks people. He is also quick-tempered and selfish. His character shows that scientific brilliance without ethical responsibility can become dangerous.

Q. How does Griffin use invisibility for selfish purposes?

Answer: Instead of using his discovery for constructive scientific work, Griffin uses invisibility to escape, steal and frighten others. He steals clothes and money, robs the clergyman's home, manipulates the mystery around the inn and resists arrest. His actions demonstrate that the value of an invention depends partly on how responsibly it is used.

Q. How does the story combine science and mystery?

Answer: The scientific explanation is that Griffin uses rare drugs to make his body transparent. This gives a rational basis for invisibility. At the same time, his invisible movements create mysterious events: footprints appear without a visible person, money disappears from an empty room and furniture seems to move on its own. The story combines scientific imagination with mystery to create

suspense.

10. Value-Based Questions

Q. What ethical lesson does the story teach about scientific discoveries?

Answer: Scientific knowledge should be used responsibly. A powerful discovery can benefit society when guided by ethics, but the same discovery can cause harm when used selfishly.

Q. Why is knowledge alone not enough?

Answer: Knowledge gives a person power, but judgement determines how that power is used. Griffin has extraordinary scientific knowledge but poor moral judgement, which makes him dangerous.

Q. How should society respond to misuse of technology?

Answer: Society needs ethical standards, laws, responsible education and accountability so that powerful technologies are used safely and do not harm others.

11. Additional Important Questions

Q. Why does Griffin set fire to his landlord's house?

Answer: He does so in revenge because the landlord tries to eject him.

Q. Why does Griffin remove his clothes after becoming invisible?

Answer: His clothes remain visible, so he must remove them to become completely unseen.

Q. Why does he need clothes again?

Answer: He cannot tolerate the cold and needs clothing for warmth and practical survival.

Q. Why does Mrs Hall suspect witchcraft?

Answer: She cannot see Griffin but sees furniture and objects apparently moving on their own, so she interprets the events as supernatural.

Q. Why is the title appropriate?

Answer: The story begins with visible footprints belonging to an invisible person, creating the central mystery of 'footprints without feet'.

12. CBSE Exam-Oriented Questions

Q. Competency-based: Griffin is scientifically brilliant but ethically irresponsible. What should modern education emphasise?

Answer: Education should combine technical knowledge with ethics, responsibility, consequences and respect for others. Skills without moral judgement can be misused.

Q. Case-based: A new technology can be used for both beneficial and harmful purposes. What principle from the story applies?

Answer: The responsible use of technology matters as much as the invention itself. Users should consider safety, consent, legality and social consequences.

Q. Analytical: 'The real danger is not invisibility but the absence of moral responsibility.' Discuss.

Answer: Invisibility is merely a capability. Griffin becomes dangerous because he uses that capability for theft, revenge and escape. His choices, rather than the scientific discovery alone, create the harm.

13. MCQs

1. Griffin was a:

A. magician B. scientist C. policeman D. teacher

2. Griffin made his body:
A. heavier B. transparent C. stronger D. smaller
3. The first visible evidence of Griffin is:
A. a hat B. footprints C. a coat D. a shadow
4. Griffin set fire to:
A. a shop B. his landlord's house C. an inn D. a theatre
5. Griffin goes to:
A. Iping B. Paris C. Lucknow D. Boston
6. Mrs Hall is the:
A. constable B. landlord's wife C. clergyman's wife D. shopkeeper
7. The clergyman's money is stolen from his:
A. bedroom B. study C. kitchen D. garden
8. Mrs Hall thinks the furniture is affected by:
A. science B. spirits C. animals D. wind
9. The constable is named:
A. Jaffers B. Henry C. Fowler D. Max
10. Griffin finally:
A. becomes visible B. is arrested C. escapes invisibly D. dies

MCQ Answer Key

1-B, 2-B, 3-B, 4-B, 5-A, 6-B, 7-B, 8-B, 9-A, 10-C

14. Teacher's Note on Answer Writing

2-3 marks: Answer directly and include the key reason/event.

5-6 marks: Use a clear opening, 3-4 developed points and a concluding inference.

Extracts: Identify context/speaker first, then answer precisely.